

Iraq



Iraq has struggled to assert its independence in a troubled history marred by foreign invasions.

c.3000 BCE Sumerian civilization flourishes in Mesopotamia, the area of modern Iraq.

c.1700 BCE Hammurabi of Babylon establishes an empire in Mesopotamia.

700s–600s BCE Assyrians rule much of Iraq from Nineveh.

539–538 BCE Persian king Cyrus the Great seizes Babylon.

331 BCE Alexander the Great takes Babylon during his conquest of the Persian empire. Iraq is ruled by his Greek successors until the 2nd century BCE, and then by the Parthians and Sassanian Persians.



Golden goat

This gold and lapis lazuli ornament was discovered in the 1920s in the Royal Tombs of Ur by British archaeologist Leonard Woolley. It dates from about 2500 BCE when Sumerian culture was at its zenith.

637 CE Muslim Arab armies take over Iraq after the battle of Jalula.

762 Baghdad founded on the banks of the Tigris by Caliph Al-Mansour as his new capital. Iraq becomes political and cultural center of the Abbasid caliphate.

900s–1000s Baghdad falls to the Shi'ite Buwaihids.

1000s The Seljuk Turks dominate Iraq.

1534 The Ottoman Sultan Suleyman conquers Baghdad. Iraq is under Ottoman control for four centuries, save for a brief Safavid Persian occupation in the 1600s.

1914 The Ottoman Empire sides with Germany during World War I. British troops invade Iraq to deprive the Central Powers of vital staging post.

1915–16 British defeated at Siege of Kut.

1916 Sykes–Picot agreement between Britain and France on the future of the Middle East after the war's end.

1917 British troops capture Baghdad.

1920 League of Nations awards mandate over Iraq to Britain, leading to an uprising in Iraq.

1921 Amir Faisal Ibn Hussein becomes first king of Iraq following a plebiscite.

1922 An Anglo-Iraqi Treaty is signed, guaranteeing the UK special interests in exchange for the establishment of a constituent assembly in Iraq.

1932 King Faisal formally proclaims Iraq an independent and sovereign state.

1948 Iraqi troops are sent to Israel to fight in the Arab–Israeli war.

1956 Iraq joins the Baghdad Pact, a pro-US alliance of West Asian powers.

1958 King Faisal II is killed in a coup. Brigadier Abd-Al-Karim Kassem becomes president.

1961 Start of Kurdish rebellion in north Iraq. Baghdad claims sovereignty over Kuwait on the eve of Kuwait's independence.

1963 Kassem overthrown in a coup led by the Arab Socialist Ba'ath Party, but the Ba'athists are in turn ousted by Colonel Abd as-Salem Muhammad Aref. Kuwait's sovereignty is recognized.

1966 Aref is succeeded by his brother, Abd ar-Rahman.

1968 Ba'athists, under Ahmad Hassan al-Bakr, take power.

1970 Revolutionary Command Council establishes manifesto on Kurdish autonomy.

1972 Nationalization of Western-controlled Iraq Petroleum Company. Treaty of Friendship and Cooperation signed with the Soviet Union.

1978 Iraq and Syria form economic and political union.

1979 Saddam Hussein replaces al-Bakr as president.

1980 Outbreak of the Iraq–Iran war, in a border dispute with the new Revolutionary Islamic government in Tehran. The Iranians seek to topple the Sunni Saddam, who they see as oppressing Iraq's Shia majority.

1981 Israeli jets attack and cripple Iraqi nuclear research facility at Osirak near Baghdad.



Abbasid splendor

From the mid-8th century, Baghdad under the Abbasids became the capital of the Islamic world, adorned with a number of splendid mosques.

1982 Shia leader Mohammed Baqir al-Hakim, exiled in Tehran, forms Supreme Council of the Islamic Revolution in Iraq.

1988 Iraq and Iran agree ceasefire.

Iraqi government forces use chemical weapons in attack on Kurdish village of Halabja.

1990 British journalist Farzad Bazoft hanged for spying. Iraq and Iran restore diplomatic relations. Iraq invades Kuwait. UN authorizes the use of force to enforce Iraqi withdrawal.

1991 Gulf War. US-led military coalition launches massive air and ground offensives, which drive the Iraqis out of Kuwait. The Iraqi regime puts down Shia rebellion. Establishment of safe haven for Kurds in northern Iraq.

1992 Western powers proclaim air exclusion zone over southern Iraq.

1994 Outbreak of Kurdish civil war. Iraq recognizes Kuwaiti sovereignty.

1995 Government minister Gen. Hussein Kamil defects to Jordan. He is murdered on his return to Iraq in February 1996.

1996 First legislative elections since 1989 are won by ruling Ba'ath Party. UN supervises limited sales of Iraq oil to purchase humanitarian supplies. Iraqi forces launch offensive into Kurdish safe haven, capturing Irbil. US expands southern air exclusion zone to just south of Baghdad.

1998–99 UN weapons inspection teams are refused reentry into Iraq; US and UK mount punitive air strikes to destroy Iraq's nuclear, biological, and chemical weapons programs.

1999 Grand Ayatollah Muhammad Sadiq al-Sadr, leader of Iraq's Shias, is assassinated in Najaf.

2002 United Nations weapons inspectors return to Iraq as UN Security Council warns of grave consequences if it does not cooperate with their investigation.

2003 American-led coalition invades Iraq on March 20, capturing Baghdad less than three weeks later. Saddam eludes capture until December. A US-led administration is installed in Baghdad, the Ba'ath party is made illegal, and the armed forces are dissolved.

2004 Anti-US insurgency mounts, with increasing attacks against coalition forces. Initially largely Sunni-led, Shia militias now join the movement to oust the US. US restores Iraqi sovereignty to government under Iyad Allawi. Major US offensive against insurgents in Fallujah.

2005 Voting takes place for a Transitional National Assembly. Increase in car bombings by insurgents. Kurdish leader Jalal Talabani becomes president of Iraq. New constitution approved by Iraqi voters. Trial of Saddam Hussein for crimes against humanity begins. Parliamentary elections leave Shia-led United Iraqi Alliance as largest party.

2006 Jawad al-Maliki becomes prime minister. Insurgency-related deaths mount dramatically: an independent study estimates that 600,000 Iraqis have died since the 2003 invasion. Leader of Al-Qaeda in Iraq, Abu Musab al-Zarqawi, is killed in US air strike. Saddam Hussein is sentenced to death and hanged.

2007 United States announces new security plan for Baghdad, but a series of car bombs in the capital kills hundreds. Former Vice President Taha Yassin Ramadan is executed. Calls for US withdrawal mount.

2007 Britain hands over control of security in Basra province to Iraqi government.

2008 United States hands over security control in Anbar province to the Iraqi government: it is the first Sunni province to be handed over to Iraqi security forces. The Iraqi parliament approves a security pact by which all American forces are to leave Iraq by the end of 2011.

2009 Prime Minister al-Maliki's political bloc wins a big victory in local elections. President Obama announces withdrawal of most US forces by late August 2010.

2010 "Chemical" Ali-Hassan al Majid is executed. Legislative elections produce no clear outcome and allegations of fraud; it takes seven months for al-Maliki to be reappointed as prime minister. The last US combat brigade leaves Iraq in August.

“The great duel, the mother of all battles has begun. The dawn of victory nears...”

IRAQI PRESIDENT SADDAM HUSSEIN ON THE IMPENDING AMERICAN OFFENSIVE TO RETAKE KUWAIT, 1991

«54–55 The Cradle of Civilization
«80–81 Rulers of the Iron Age
«200–01 The Crusades
«468–69 The Gulf Wars